



Norway: Two Career Paths in a Dyadic Executive Structure

Bjørn Mo Forum*

Abstract

Are the boundaries between political and bureaucratic careers in Norway becoming blurred, and what is the role of deputy ministers (*statssekretærer*)? While often studied as advisers, deputy ministers wield executive power as second-in-command within ministerial hierarchies. Examining comprehensive career data on 221 ministers, deputy ministers, and top bureaucrats, this chapter finds a persistent separation. Top bureaucrats pursue careers almost exclusively in public administration (only 6.8% have political experience), while deputy ministers demographically and professionally resemble ministers, rather than constituting a distinct category. These patterns demonstrate minimal politicization of the bureaucracy, while also challenging the conventional categorization of deputy ministers. This suggests that Norway's executive structure is dyadic rather than triangular.

Keywords: bureaucratic careers, political careers, politicization, meritocracy, Norway

5912 words

* PhD Research Fellow, Department of Political Science, University of Oslo. Email: b.m.forum@stv.uio.no.



Highlights

- The Norwegian executive ‘triangle’ is dyadic, consisting of 74 executive politicians (20 ministers, 54 deputy ministers) and 147 top bureaucrats with separate career paths. Deputy ministers maintain the adviser role yet wield executive power.
- Top bureaucrats have careers spent almost completely within central administration, while both types of executive politicians largely follow full-time political trajectories.
- Both groups demonstrate near-equal gender distribution, with executive politicians having 5% more males, while top bureaucrats show a 2% female advantage.
- Party-political background is essential for ministerial office, conversely only 6.8% of top bureaucrats have any political experience, indicating minimal politicisation of the bureaucracy.

1. Introduction

“Here in the ministry, I can have two jobs. Minister or messenger. Anything else, I’m not qualified for.” (Trygve Bratteli, 1951 as cited in Støre, 2023).

In this fashion Trygve Bratteli greeted the civil servants in the Norwegian Ministry of Finance when entering office as finance minister in 1951. Bratteli, who later also served as prime minister, had the career path of a labour party politician typical of the post-World War II era in Norway, no higher education, some work experience in blue collar professions followed by a purely political career (Askim et al., 2024). This quote illustrates the belief in two separate career paths of executive politicians and top bureaucrats, each with their own specific functions. This sentiment is largely shared by ministers and top bureaucrats in Norway (Christensen & Lægreid, 2002). However, the current prime minister from the Labour party Jonas Gahr Støre who quoted Bratteli in his message to new students at Norwegian universities in 2023, is a prominent example of a very different career path. Støre holds a Master’s degree in political science from Sciences Po Paris and made it to the top of the civil service at the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO) before deciding to enter politics. This suggests the traditional separation between political and bureaucratic career paths may be becoming blurred.



Executive politicians, advisers and top bureaucrats have been studied extensively for decades in Norway – notably the separation between politics and bureaucracy (Christensen et al., 2018; Jacobsen, 1960; Lægreid & Olsen, 1978). This chapter takes a novel approach by studying the career paths of both politicians and bureaucrats more extensively and holistically than previous research that has tended to separately study the careers of ministers (Askim et al., 2024; Mangset, 2025; Søyland, 2017), political advisers (Askim et al., 2021; Kolltveit & Thorsen, 2018) and top bureaucrats (Askim et al., 2022; Askim & Bach, 2021; Kolltveit & Figenschou, 2020; Nerland, 1998). This chapter uses data on the complete careers of all ministers, deputy ministers and level 1 to 2 bureaucrats who were in office at the start of July 2024 to provide an extensive description of the similarities and differences between the careers of bureaucrats and politicians in the Støre coalition government, which was in office from October 2021 to February 2025.

Dissecting and comparing the careers of 74 executive politicians and 147 top bureaucrats, the chapter reveals a picture of separation between the career paths of the two groups which is largely consistent with previous research, while complicating conventional characterisations of deputy ministers as advisers. In the context of the comparative study of executive triangles, it is important to note the absence of a hierarchical advisory structure outside of the bureaucracy in Norway. Instead, the advisory role is maintained by deputy ministers, who also wield executive power as the second-in-command in the ministerial hierarchies (Askim et al., 2017). Challenging perceptions of deputy ministers as advisers, the analysis reveals that deputy ministers and senior executive politicians share largely similar demographics and career paths. The separation between bureaucratic and political career paths suggests that politicisation of the bureaucracy remains limited, as nearly all top bureaucrats have spent most of their career within the central administration. Executive politicians follow more diverse career paths, but most have almost strictly political careers – in line with trends over time of professionalisation of politics in Norway (Askim et al., 2024).



The Structure and Composition of the Executive Triangle

Norway is a parliamentary monarchy, where the King serves as the Ceremonial Head of State, and the Prime Minister serves as the Head of Government. The state is unitary with three levels of government. This chapter focuses on the executive triangle at the central level. The electoral system is characterised by party-list proportional representation elections to the unicameral parliament (*Storting*) being held at fixed intervals (no dissolution power for any actor) every four years. There is no investiture vote in the parliament to install new governments; the executive government is only politically accountable to the parliament through the parliament's ability to launch no-confidence procedures. Moreover, executive-legislative relations are not only characterised by the collective responsibility of the executive government to the legislative assembly, but also the portfolio minister's individual responsibility for any action taken within their delegated portfolios. Yet, governments are characterised by a high degree of collective decision-making, where the prime minister is considered the first among equals, described by Olsen (1983, p. 83) as a “political organizer but no superstar”.

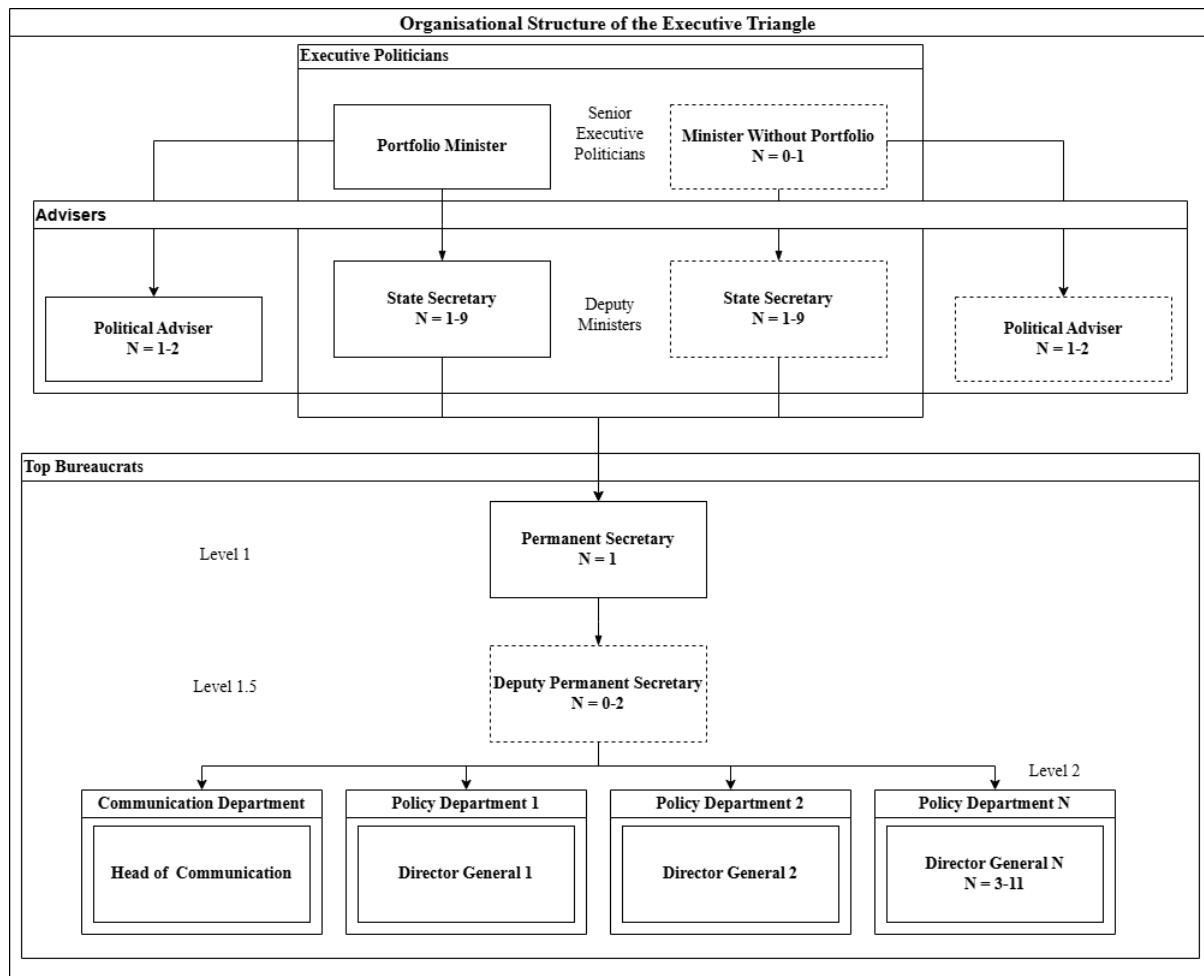
Barring occasional changes to the number of ministries and the number of people employed in different positions within the executive triangle, the ministerial structure has remained largely unchanged since the role and hierarchical placement of deputy ministers and permanent secretaries were formalised in 1981 (Forbruker- og administrasjonsdepartementet, 1984).

The Støre Government – which were in office when the July 2024 snapshot was taken – ascended to office in October 2021. This centre-left coalition government consisted of 20 ministers from the Labour Party (*Arbeiderpartiet*) and the Centre Party (*Senterpartiet*). Including the PMO, Norway has 17 ministries that follow the structure in Figure 1. Three ministries employ multiple senior executive politicians. These ministries have an additional cabinet minister with delegated responsibilities within specific areas of the ministry portfolio but who reports to a different cabinet minister who heads the ministry. For example, the Minister of International Development is attached to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs but is



delegated responsibility for the international development aspect of the portfolio by the Foreign Minister.

Figure 1: Organisational Structure of the Executive Triangle in Norway



Note: Dotted borders denote position that do not exist in all ministries. The PMO follows the same structure as other ministries. Political Advisers are employed outside of the ministerial hierarchy. N denotes the range (minimum to maximum number) of people employed in a position within different ministries as of July 2024.

The ministries are organised by policy areas, to develop and carry out policy within their delegated portfolio. The only ministry with no unique policy area authority is the PMO. It serves as a centre of government, tasked with supporting the Prime Minister, facilitating decision-making within the government's collective decision-making bodies, and contributing



to cross-portfolio coordination. The ministries are hierarchical structures with executive political leadership at the top, where the portfolio minister is the head of the ministry (the minister without portfolio ranges as number two, if such a minister exists) and the deputy ministers are the second in command after the minister(s). The administrative head of the ministerial bureaucracy is the Permanent Secretary, who reports to both the minister and the deputy ministers. Under the Permanent Secretary exist a deputy permanent secretary (*assisterende departementsråd*) in 4 of the 17 ministries, a head of the communication department (*kommunikasjonssjef*) and 3-11 directors general of ministry departments (*ekspedisjonssjefer*). At the third level of the administrative hierarchy there are 418 deputy directors general of ministry departments (*avdelingsdirektører*), most of these are not included in the executive triangle as they do not have the same privileged access to the political leadership as the Level 1 and Level 2 bureaucrats (NOU 2023: 21). Moreover, ministerial departments may oversee the steering of semi-autonomous agencies hierarchically placed under the ministries. The leadership of these agencies are not considered part of the executive triangle. In total, 4,549 bureaucrats are employed in the ministries, while the agencies employ 174,781 persons (DFØ, 2024).

Figure 1 shows that hierarchically organised cabinets of advisers outside of the ministerial hierarchy do not exist in the same way as in countries in the Napoleonic administrative tradition (Brans & Pickering, 2020). Outside of the ministerial hierarchy each minister employs one to two political advisers. These positions are typically inhabited by young up-and-coming politicians (usually in their 20s to 30s) who function more as bag-carriers than political/policy advisers for the ministers (Kolltveit & Thorsen, 2018). These 20 political advisers – who are attached to the minister personally and thus fit this definition – are excluded from the CoREx dataset (and thus from this chapter) as the criteria for inclusion of advisers has been the existence of a hierarchical advisory structure, where only the managing and chief advisers are included across countries.

Table 1: Composition of the Executive Triangle by Category and Subcategory



Executive Triangle Category (ETC)	Executive Triangle Subcategory (ETSC)	Executive Triangle Position (ETP)	N (%)	Original ETP title
Executive Politicians	Senior Executive Politicians	Prime minister	1 (0.45)	Statsminister
		Minister with portfolio	16 (7.24)	Statsråd
		Minister without portfolio	3 (1.36)	Statsråd uten portefølje
	Deputy Ministers And Equivalents	Deputy minister or equivalent	54 (24.43)	Statssekretær
		Subtotal	74 (33.48)	
Top Bureaucrats	Secretary Generals	Chief secretary general	17 (7.69)	Departementsråd
	Director Generals	Deputy secretary general	125 (56.56)	Ekspedisjonssjef, Kommunikasjonssjef, Avdelingsdirektør, Generalmajor, Kontrolldirektør, Stabsdirektør, Statens personaldirektør
		Policy director general	5 (2.26)	Assisterende Departementsråd
		Subtotal	147 (66.52)	
		Grand Total	221 (100.00)	

In the Norwegian system, the main advisory role is placed with the political appointees within the ministerial hierarchy – the 54 deputy ministers – as visualised in Figure 1 (see also Table 1). Previously, these deputy ministers have been treated as ministerial advisers in the literature and studied with regard to their roles within the ministry and their behaviour vis-à-vis the top



bureaucrats (Bach et al., 2025). Askim et al. (2017) find that the roles of deputy ministers may vary, spanning from advising to being a stand-in for the minister. Moreover, in coalition governments some deputy ministers are also appointed to ministries headed by a minister from another party, serving both as a source of cross partisan advice, a watchdog for their parties and reliving the minister in governing the ministry (Askim et al., 2018). Deviating from this scholarship this chapter puts emphasis on the deputy minister's formal placement within the ministerial hierarchy and categorises them together with the ministers as executive politicians. However, given their dual role as advisers and executive politicians, the analysis will also explore the question of whether the deputy ministers and the senior executive politicians constitute a coherent group or two separate paths of party-political specialisation.

On the bureaucratic side, Table 1 shows that the 147 top bureaucrats consist of the (deputy) permanent secretaries, heads of communication, directors general of ministry departments, as well as eight other positions with a different title that oversee department level units in the bureaucracy. These positions are at the two highest levels of the administrative side of the ministry and are usually all part of the ministry's administrative leader group (Figenschou et al., 2023). Moreover, Table 1 highlights that most Norwegian executive triangle members are top bureaucrats, of which 58.8% are Level 2 bureaucrats.

The Norwegian constitution places both executive politicians and top bureaucrats within the legal definition of civil servants (NOU 2023: 21). However, the constitution makes a distinction between executive politicians as 'political civil servants', appointed because of political criteria, and the top bureaucrats as 'administrative civil servants', appointed purely on meritocratic criteria. The tenure of the ministers is dependent on the confidence of the parliament, as they can be removed by a vote of no-confidence or replaced by the prime minister at will. The deputy ministers are appointed by the cabinet and have their employment tied to a minister, meaning that, at the latest a deputy minister must leave office when the minister they are appointed to serve, leaves office. In the event of a prime minister wanting to keep a deputy minister but replace a minister, the deputy minister would first be dismissed and then reappointed as deputy minister for the new minister. The administrative civil servants in



the ministries are employed on a permanent basis and cannot be dismissed for political reasons (NOU 2023: 21).

2. Transparency of the Executive Triangle

Fundamental data on every position in the executive triangle was taken from Forum (2024). This dataset has information about the entry and exit dates of all people holding such positions, as well as their education, age and gender. These data were originally sourced from yearly Who-is-who books published by the government between 1877 and 2010 and from the government's official webpages (*regjeringen.no*). The author gathered additional career data about these individuals and coded variables in line with the Corex WG2 codebook in April and June 2025. The three primary sources used in this process were the government webpages (used in 100% of cases), LinkedIn (64.7% of cases) and media reports (34.8% of cases).

The coding procedure involved starting from the information about the person on *regjeringen.no* where all individuals holding executive triangle positions have their own personal page. These pages are usually sparsely populated with biographic information outside of name and position but did in some cases – particularly for executive politicians – also contain a CV. Secondly, the minutes from the Council of State meeting, where the appointments to positions are announced, was scoured for press releases. These press releases usually contain some information about the age, education and professional qualifications of the person appointed. The next step was to conduct a Google search to look for career information on online encyclopaedias, in the news media, other public websites or on LinkedIn.

Comprehensive information to reconstruct career steps back to the start of their career were available for 97.3% of executive triangle members. However, this information was often scattered across multiple sources, with complete CVs for the most part only being transparently provided on government webpages for the senior executive politicians. Overall, career information was comprehensive for all positions, barring deputy ministers (incomplete information for 5.4%) and Level 2 bureaucrats (incomplete information for 1.4%). In other words, transparency of careers was worse for positions on the lower end of the hierarchical



layer of executive politicians and top bureaucrats. In this regard, the deputy ministers are, similar to advisers in other countries, the least transparent corner of the executive triangle.

3. Demographic Features: Gender & Age

Demographic features can be important background factors for later career choices. Hence, before turning to the comparisons of career paths, differences in demographic and education are investigated. When it comes to gender, 49.3% of the members of the executive triangle are female. There is about equal representation for bureaucratic positions (52% female, 48% male), whereas the gender gap is larger for executive politicians as there are 5-6% more male senior executive politicians and deputy minister (if the 20 political advisers outside of the definition of executive politicians are included the gender gap in representation falls to 2%). The gender gap for executive politicians is in line with previous research showing that the share of female ministers has been stable at around 45% since the 1980s (Askim et al., 2024). Gender balance as well as geographical representation are important norms when governments are formed, hence the share of female executive politicians has tended to be higher than the overall share of female politicians (Askim et al., 2024). Research points towards the gender gap in Norwegian politics being partially explained by gendered differences in ambitions for elected and appointed political office (Kolltveit, 2022), and by differences in how men and women with children are ranked on party lists (Fiva & King, 2024). Additionally, there are gender gaps in access to single-occupant positions in local politics that are important stepping stones for later appointments as executive politicians (Smith et al., 2025).

For top bureaucrats, the slight overrepresentation of women has been the result of a gradual change over the last 50 years – these positions were historically only staffed by men until the appointment of Elsa Bråten as Director General for the Family and Gender Equality Department in the Ministry of Consumer Affairs and Administration in 1977 (Forum, 2026). There has been limited focus on gender in the literature on top bureaucrats in Norway, but the 52% increase in female representation at the top of the ministerial hierarchy displayed is even higher than the 36% increase that Christensen et al. (2018) observed among all ministerial bureaucrats from 19% in 1976 to 55% in 2016. However, whereas women are overrepresented



among top bureaucrats, their overrepresentation is still lower than across all other positions within the bureaucracy.

There is a large difference in the age distribution between top bureaucrats and executive politicians. The median top bureaucrat (55 years old) is 9 years older than the median executive politician (46 years old) and 12.5 years older than the median deputy minister (42.5 years old). Age-wise, the Norwegian executive politicians are young compared with most other countries (Nyrup et al., 2025). There has been a gradual decrease in age throughout the 20th century, from the average minister being 55 years old at the dawn of the century (Askim et al., 2024). Hence, top bureaucrats and executive politicians do not appear to be selected from the same, but rather from different age groups.

4. Education

How do the members of the executive triangle differ in education? Table 2 shows that all top bureaucrats have higher education, with 89% holding a Master's degree. Conversely, the executive politicians in Norway have historically been among the least educated in the world (Nyrup et al., 2025), although about 90% of senior executive politicians now hold at least a Bachelor's degree (65% have a Master's degree). However, they are still more educated than the people they are elected to represent, although the gap between the share of executive politicians with higher education and the general population has fallen in the last 50 years (Mangset, 2025). Compared to top bureaucrats, but also heads of private companies, executive politicians reach their top positions with lower educational attainment (Mangset, 2025). Moreover, there is little difference in educational attainment between deputy ministers and senior executive politicians. Consequently, the expert advice deputy ministers provide is not based on superior educational credentials compared to the senior executive politicians they serve, and both groups have lower educational attainment than top bureaucrats.



Table 2: Highest Educational Attainment of Executive Triangle Officials

Education Level	Executive Politicians	Top Bureaucrats	Total
Doctoral or equivalent	1 (1.4%)	10 (6.8%)	11 (5%)
Master's or equivalent	48 (64.9%)	131 (89.1%)	179 (81%)
Bachelor's or equivalent	19 (25.7%)	6 (4.1%)	25 (11.3%)
Short-cycle tertiary	3 (4.1%)	0 (0.0%)	3 (1.4%)
Post-secondary non-tertiary education	1 (1.4%)	0 (0.0%)	1 (0.5%)
Upper secondary education	2 (2.7%)	0 (0.0%)	2 (0.9%)
Total	74 (100%)	147 (100%)	221 (100%)

The members of the executive triangle hold degrees from 64 different institutions. The three largest universities in the three largest cities account for 51% of their degrees. The University of Oslo stands out as the most common educational breeding ground for all positions within the executive triangle: 37% of deputy ministers, 40% of ministers and 54% of top bureaucrats hold a degree from this institution. Place of education is more heterogeneous for executive politicians than for top bureaucrats, as top bureaucrats are more concentrated across institutions (2.9 per institution on average) than executive politicians (2 per institution).

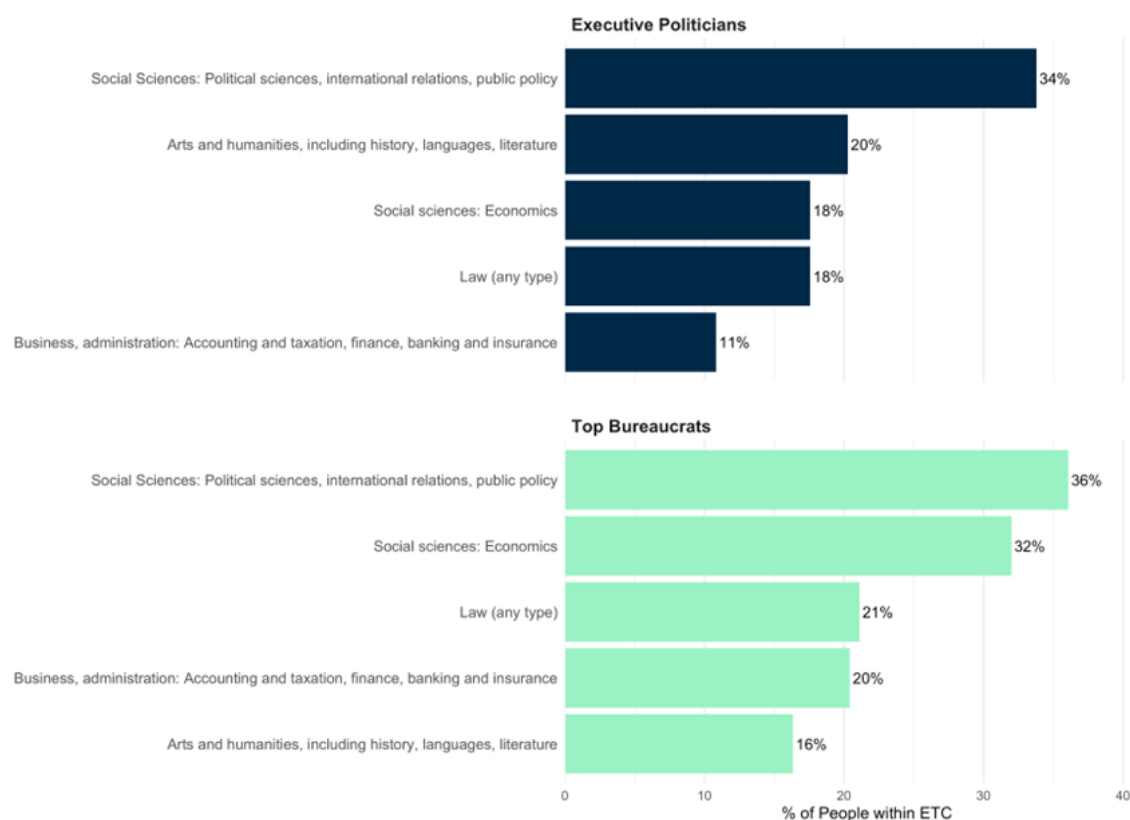
Whereas deputy ministers resemble senior executive politicians in educational attainment, age and gender, they are 12% more likely to have studied abroad. Overall, 37% studied abroad, 40% of top bureaucrats and deputy ministers with a university degree, compared to 28% of senior executive politicians. Similarly, 22% hold a degree from abroad, a number that is largely driven by 25% of top bureaucrats holding such a degree. 20% of deputy ministers have a degree from abroad, with 5 out of 10 deputy ministers having their degree from the London School of



Economics and Political Science. Prime Minister Støre is the only senior executive politician who holds a degree from abroad.

Turning to the field of study, Figure 2 shows that political science is the most common subject of study. More than a third of both executive politicians and top bureaucrats have studied this subject. Law, which has historically been dominant among both bureaucrats (Christensen et al., 2018) and executive politicians (Askim et al., 2024), is only the third most frequent subject of study for both senior executive politicians (20%) and top bureaucrats (21%), and the fourth most common for deputy ministers (17%). Top bureaucrats deviate from executive politicians when it comes to having a degree in economics (32% vs. 18%) or business studies (20% vs 11%). Conversely, degrees in humanities are slightly more common among executive politicians (20%) than among top bureaucrats (16%).

Figure 2: Distribution of Educational Subjects: Top Five Fields by Executive Triangle Category





In summary, the differences between the positions in the executive triangle are as follows: Top bureaucrats can be distinguished from executive politicians by their higher share of women, older age profile and higher educational attainment. Furthermore, they are more likely to bring economic and business expertise to the executive triangle. Executive politicians, meanwhile, show some minor differences in terms of education. Otherwise, deputy ministers largely mirror the demographic characteristics of the senior executive politicians. Thus far, the evidence suggests that executive politicians and top bureaucrats are drawn from slightly different pools of candidates. However, deviations in educational background are insufficient to indicate that divergent career paths begin with educational choices. Hence, the next section turns to the question of whether access to the political and bureaucratic corners of the executive triangle is shaped by career choices.

5. Careers

Figures 3 and 4 present career step maps for executive politicians and top bureaucrats. Each horizontal bar represents the career of an individual. Bar colours indicate the sector or job type at each career step (10 categories), relative to appointment to the current executive triangle position (lower “car. pos.” number indicate more recent positions). Bar length varies between people due to differences in age, labour market entry timing, and job switching frequency. Another factor that may impact bar length is missing information. While career information is comprehensive for almost all individuals, data on early-career positions may be less complete, as entry level work may have been omitted from CVs. However, career information exists from at least age 30 onwards for 94% of individuals.



Figure 3: Map of Career Steps of Executive Politicians

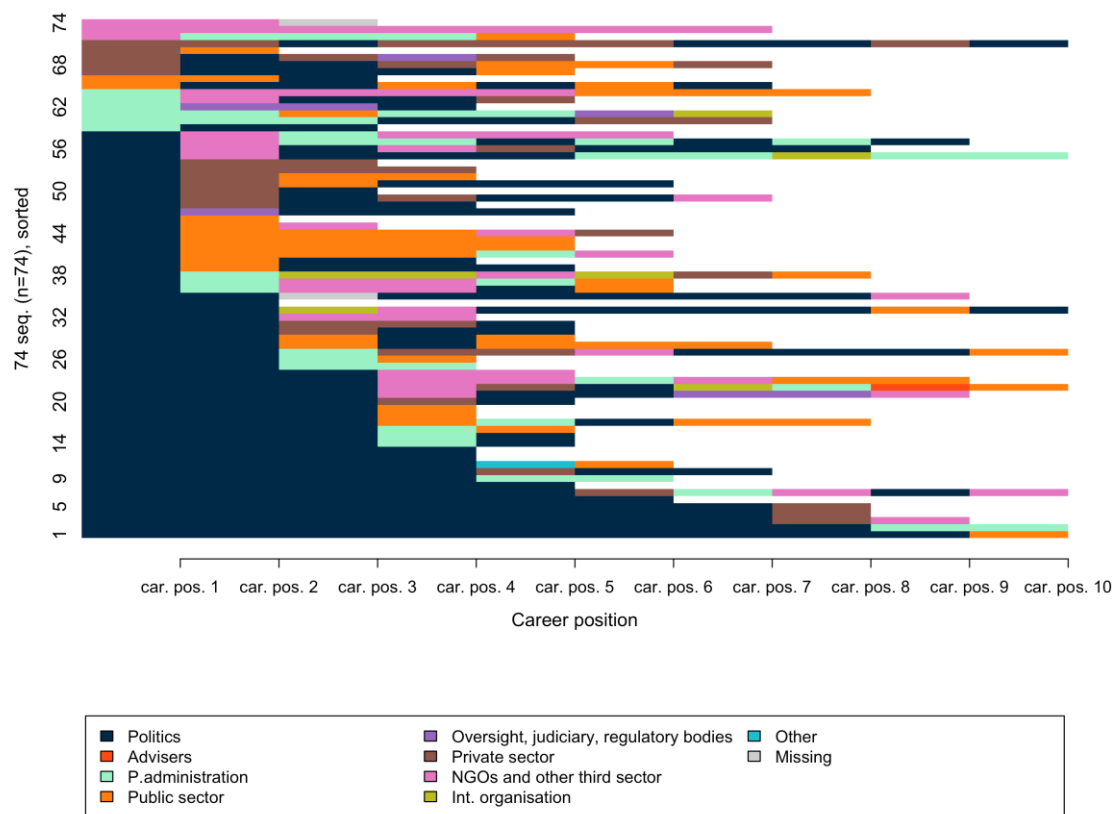
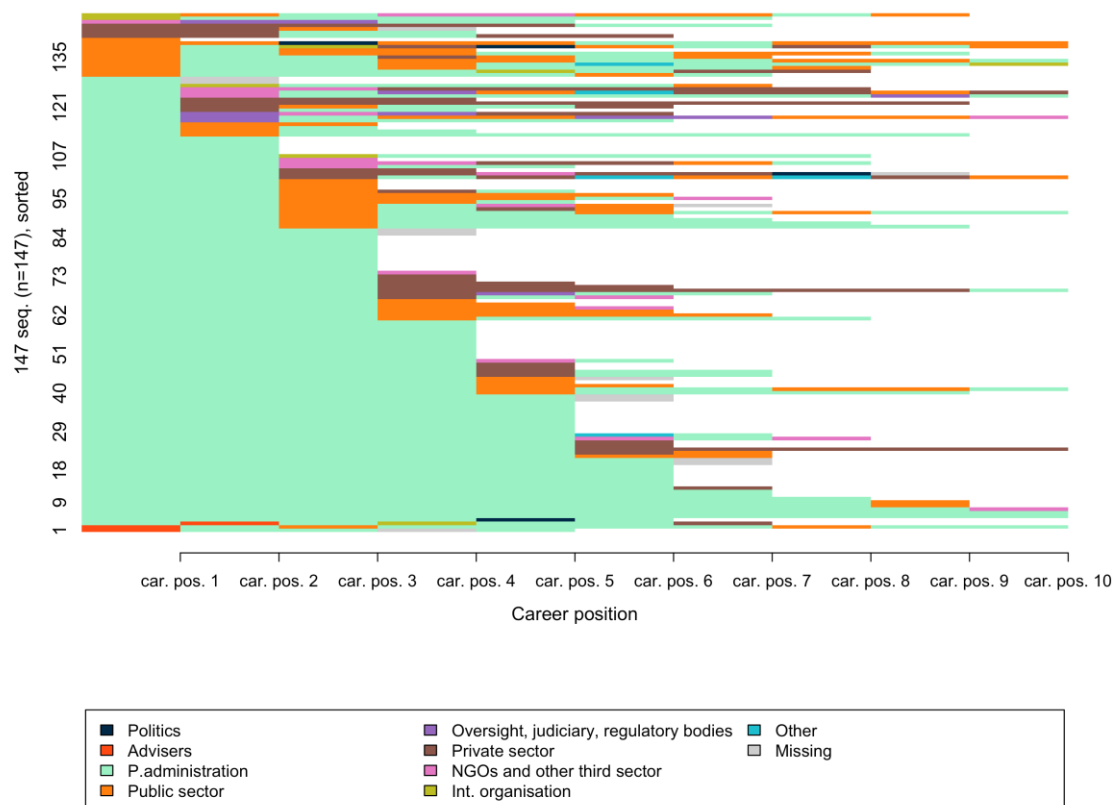




Figure 4: Map of Career Steps of Top Bureaucrats



A visual comparison of Figures 3 and 4 shows that the career paths of top bureaucrats clearly differ from those of executive politicians with almost every top bureaucrat having spent most of their career within the central administration. This is further corroborated by Table 3 revealing that 86.4% of top bureaucrats are recruited directly from another position within public administration. Furthermore, 99% of top bureaucrats have been employed in the central administration during their career and 86% have also previously held a senior position within



public administration. Only 3% of top bureaucrats have had political employment and none have held elected office.

Table 3: Most Frequent Sector of Last Jobs of Executive Triangle Categories

Group	Most frequent sector of last job	Second most frequent sector of last job	Third most frequent sector of last job
Executive Politicians	Politics: 58 (78.4%)	Public Administration: 6 (8.1%)	Private Sector: 5 (6.8%)
Top Bureaucrats	Public Administration: 127 (86.4%)	Public Sector: 11 (7.5%)	Private Sector: 4 (2.7%)

Conversely, as can be seen in Figure 3 and Table 3 the careers of executive politicians are largely political, with 78.4% having a political position as their last form of employment. However, there are notable differences between the political career paths of deputy ministers and senior executive politicians. Employment in elected office dominates for senior executive politicians with 90% having had such an experience at least once before their current appointment, while this share is 36 percentage points lower for deputy ministers (54% have held such a position).

All senior executive politicians have had a political position prior to their current appointment, while 11% of deputy ministers have never had a political position as their main form of employment. Having had a non-elected political position as their main job is 9 percentage points more common for deputy ministers (65%) than for senior executive politicians (74%). It is also not uncommon for ministers to first have held a position as deputy minister before being appointed to a more senior position, as 40% of senior executive politicians previously held such a role. Furthermore, 31% of deputy ministers have revolved in and out of this role at least once before their current appointment. Askim et al. (2021) have previously found that deputy minister posts often serve as stepping stones to higher positions both within and outside



of politics. Overall, the executive career map is more diverse for executive politicians – for the deputy ministers in particular – than for top bureaucrats. The diversity in deputy minister careers may be a consequence of the different roles they may have in praxis (Askim et al., 2017) and the need to represent diverse interest during government formation bargaining.

An example of this diversity is the 6 deputy ministers with careers (largely) outside politics. This group of individuals seems to be appointed to provide advice that represents the organised interests of important groups within the ministry's portfolio. An example here is Erlend Hanstveit, deputy minister in the Ministry of Culture, who previously had a non-political career working as a professional football player and head of the Norwegian Players' Association. Similarly, Sigve Bolstad appears to represent the organised interests of the police union, which he led prior to his appointment as a deputy minister in the Ministry of Justice, without any previous political experience.

6. Political Experience

The last section showed that the career paths of top bureaucrats and executive politicians had limited overlap, indicating that the expertise brought to the executive triangle by these two groups differs. However, it does not by itself imply that the selection of executive politicians is politicised or that the selection of top bureaucrats is not, only that there are different expectations about the expertise that the different groups of the executive triangle bring to the table. Top bureaucrats also have political preferences, and these can be (un)aligned with those of changing governments. If new governments consider top bureaucratic positions as portfolios that they can staff politically, the expectation is that the tenure of top bureaucrats and executive politicians will be largely identical. Accordingly, previous research in the Norwegian context has found that turnover among top bureaucrats increased after a change in government (Askim et al., 2022) and that 5-11% of top bureaucrats usually have some form of political affiliation (Bach et al., 2025).

Regarding party affiliation, the findings align with previous research as only 6.8% of top bureaucrats have a partisan affiliation, compared to all of the executive politicians being party-



affiliated. Although the share of top bureaucrats with a partisan affiliation is 4 percentage points higher than the share that had held a political position during their career, it remains low and consistent with the proportion observed over the past 140 years (Bach et al., 2025).

The median top bureaucrat has been in their position for 3.7 years, whereas the average executive politician has only been in office for 9.7 months. The highest number of years that a bureaucrat had been in position is 28, whereas for politicians the corresponding statistic is 2.7 years. In other words, there is limited overlap of the distribution of tenure between politicians and bureaucrats, implying that the tenure of bureaucrats is largely unaffected by the elections of new governments. Nevertheless, it is worth noting that 49% of top bureaucrats have been appointed after the last change of government, and their average employment length is lower than the average employment length of top bureaucrats in the last 140 years (Forum, 2026). This increased staffing instability could be explained by the heightened political control within ministries, as the number of deputy ministers has grown and top bureaucrats now serve governments with more polarized preferences, including populist parties critical of bureaucratic elites (Bach et al., 2025). Alternatively, this pattern may reflect general trends toward greater labour market mobility, with ‘agencification’ and expanding state-owned enterprises creating outside opportunities that make lifelong ministerial careers less attractive.

7. Conclusion

Previous research on the careers of ministers, political advisers and top bureaucrats in Norway has tended to study these groups separately. Drawing on the concept of the executive triangle, and utilising highly granular career data, this chapter has dissected and compared the careers of the 221 members of the Norwegian executive triangle who were in office at the start of July 2024: 147 top bureaucrats, 20 cabinet ministers, and 54 deputy ministers. While deputy ministers are often conceptualised as straddling adviser and executive politician roles (Askim et al., 2017), the findings challenge this characterisation. Deputy ministers do not differ significantly from senior executive politicians in most respects, suggesting their advisory function is largely limited to the political experience they contribute.



The chapter revealed a separation between the career paths of executive politicians and top bureaucrats, which is largely in line with previous research. Gender distribution approaches parity in both political and bureaucratic positions, although executive politicians remain slightly male-dominated (55% male, 45% female). For top bureaucrats, the gender gap is 2% but flipped. Age-wise top bureaucrats are on average in their mid-50s, about 10 years older than the average executive politician, who is comparatively young (Nyrup et al., 2025). Almost all top bureaucrats have a Master's degree. Conversely, only 65% of executive politicians have a Master's degree. However, they are still higher educated than the general adult population in Norway (Mangset, 2025). Careerwise just about all top bureaucrats have spent most of their career within public administration. Conversely, both senior executive politicians and deputy ministers have predominantly political careers, though deputy ministers display greater career diversity. While most executive politicians follow a trajectory centred on seeking and attaining elected office, the paths of deputy ministers are more varied: some follow similar elected office trajectories, others serve primarily in non-elected party roles, and a small group enter from predominantly non-political backgrounds.

A final important finding refers to the level of politicisation in the executive triangle: whereas a party-political background remains vital to gain access to political office as a minister or deputy minister, only 6.8% of top bureaucrats have any form of political experience. Moreover, there is a low correlation between the tenure of executive politicians and top bureaucrats, but with indications of temporal dependence between the careers of bureaucrats and politicians having increased in recent years. However, although the findings are largely in line with previous research, the findings may have limited temporal generalisability, since the study was limited to the make-up of the executive triangle at a single point in time. Future research could investigate how the career paths of the members of the executive triangle have changed over time and investigate differences in the make-up of the executive triangle under governments from different sides of the political spectrum.

Returning to the introductory quote, the career paths of politicians may have shifted towards more professionalisation and higher education since Trygve Bratteli became Minister of



Finance in 1951 (Askim et al., 2024), but the separation between executive politics and top bureaucratic career paths remains largely stable. Today's executive politicians are educationally qualified to be more than messengers in the Norwegian ministries. However, their career paths remain predominantly political, with minimal circulation between the political and the bureaucratic corners of the executive triangle. Thus, the primary change in ministerial staffing is not a blurring of bureaucratic and political career boundaries, but rather that ministers and deputy ministers now largely possess the same qualifications.



References

- Askim, J., & Bach, T. (2021). Mellom meritokrati og politisering? En kompetansestudie av etatsledere med og uten politikerbakgrunn, 1980-2020. *Norsk Statsvitenskapelig Tidsskrift*, 37(4), 171–190.
- Askim, J., Bach, T., & Christensen, J. G. (2022). Political change and administrative turnover in meritocratic systems. *West European Politics*, 0(0), 1–27.
- Askim, J., Flo, Y., Holmøyvik, E., Kolltveit, K., Mangset, M., & Rasch, B. E. (2024). *Regjeringen: Historien, makten og hverdagen* (1. utgave). Fagbokforlaget.
- Askim, J., Karlsen, R., & Kolltveit, K. (2017). Political appointees in executive government: Exploring and explaining roles using a large-N survey in Norway. *Public Administration*.
- Askim, J., Karlsen, R., & Kolltveit, K. (2018). The spy who loved me? Cross-partisans in the core executive. *Public Administration*, 96(2), 243–258.
- Askim, J., Karlsen, R., & Kolltveit, K. (2021). Public Office as a Stepping-Stone? Investigating the Careers of Ministerial Advisors. *Political Studies Review*, 19(4), 539–557.
- Bach, T., Forum, B. M., & Hesstvedt, S. (2025). Norway: Formal and informal politicization in a merit bureaucracy. In B. G. Peters, C. Knox, F. Panizza, K. Staroňová, & C. Ramos (Eds.), *Handbook of Politicization and Political Patronage*. Edward Elgar.
- Brans, M., & Pickering, H. (2020). Government Ministers and Their “Special” Advisers. *Journal of Public Administration Research and Theory*, 30(3), 521–523.
- Christensen, T., Egeberg, M., Lægreid, P., & Trondal, J. (2018). Sentralforvaltningen: Stabilitet og endring gjennom 40 år. Universitetsforlaget.
- Christensen, T., & Lægreid, P. (2002). Reformer og lederskap: Omstilling i den utøvende makt. Universitetsforlaget.
- DFØ. (2024). *Utviklingen i antall ansatte i staten*.
- Figenschou, T. U., Karlsen, R., & Kolltveit, K. (2023). Between spin doctor and information provider: Conceptualizing communication professionals in government ministries. *Public Administration*, 101(3), 1115–1133.
- Fiva, J. H., & King, M.-E. M. (2024). Child Penalties in Politics. *The Economic Journal*, 134(658), 648–670.



- Forbruker- og administrasjonsdepartementet. (1984). *Reglement for departementenes organisasjon og saksbehandling*.
- Forum, B. M. (2026). *Bureaucratic Turnover Under New Governments: The Moderating Effect of Bureaucratic and Political Layering* [Working Paper].
- Jacobsen, K. D. (1960). Lojalitet, nøytralitet og faglig uavhengighet i sentraladministrasjonen. *Tidsskrift for Samfunnsforskning*, 1(1), 231–248.
- Kolltveit, K. (2022). Gender and ambitions for elected and appointed political positions: Insights from Norway. *European Journal of Politics and Gender*, 5(1), 109–125.
- Kolltveit, K., & Figenschou, T. U. (2020). Kommunikasjonsrådgiverne i norske departementer: En «ny» type byråkrater i skjæringsfeltet mellom politikk og administrasjon? *Norsk Statsvitenskapelig Tidsskrift*, 36(2), 102–119.
- Kolltveit, K., & Thorsen, I. V. (2018). De politiske rådgiverne: Unge broilere eller betrodde (fag)medarbeidere? *Norsk Statsvitenskapelig Tidsskrift*, 34(1), 21–39.
- Lægreid, P., & Olsen, J. P. (1978). *Byråkrati og beslutninger: En studie av norske departement*. Universitetsforlaget.
- Mangset, M. (2025). Representativitet blant norske regjeringsmedlemmer mellom 1945 og 2023: I spenning mellom forventning om likhet og forventning om kompetanse. *Norsk Statsvitenskapelig Tidsskrift*, 41(3), 134–144.
- Nerland, S. (1998). Politiske verv og embetsmannskarrierer: En gjennomgang av karriererne til den norske sentralforvaltningens toppledere med utgangspunkt i årene 1936, 1956, 1976 og 1996. *Nordisk Administrativt Tidsskrift*, 1(79), 37–48.
- NOU 2023: 21. (2023). *Embetsordningen – i takt med tiden*. Kommunal- og distriktsdepartementet.
- Nyrup, J., Knutsen, C. H., Langsæther, P. E., & Kristiansen, I. L. (2025). Paths to Power: A New Dataset on the Social Profile of Governments. *British Journal of Political Science*, 55, e129.
- Olsen, J. P. (1983). *Organized democracy: Political institutions in a welfare state, the case of Norway*. Oxford University Press.
- Smith, D. M., Cirone, A., Teele, D. L., Cox, G. W., & Fiva, J. H. (2025). Hidden Majoritarianism and Women's Career Progression in Proportional Representation Systems. *American Political Science Review*, 1–19.



Søyland, M. (2017). Survival of the Ministers: On Ministerial Durability in Postwar Norway.

Scandinavian Political Studies, 40(2), 182–206.

Støre, J. G. (2023, August 17). Tenk høyt, tenk vidt, tenk fritt! En hilsen til 300.000

studenter: Norge trenger tankene deres. *Klassekampen*.